CHINA LIVING · FOOD & HERITAGE

China Travel Kit

A practical guide for your first trip to China

Hi, I'm Lao Ai. I live in Shanghai, and for over twenty years work has taken me to nearly every corner of China — everywhere except Tibet. This little booklet is the list I actually send friends before they get on a plane.

Everything in it is verifiable and usable the moment you land: which visa route applies, how to pay with a foreign card, when train tickets go on sale, who to call when things go wrong. I check the figures against official notices and update the Kit every month, because these rules do change. Before you travel, the live information on the official pages is the final word.

One thing, though, and I'd rather say it up front: **this Kit is written for everyone. Your trip isn't.** Your passport, your month, your number of days, the people you're travelling with — they change the answer. At the end of each chapter I've left one question. Reply and tell me, and I'll work it out for your trip.

Lao Ai · Shanghai

> FOUR LINES ARE ENOUGH
>
> Your country / the month you're coming / how many days / who's travelling with you (children, elderly parents, food allergies)

1. Getting In: Visas & Visa-Free Entry

Unilateral visa-free entry — up to 30 days

Holders of ordinary passports from **49 countries** can enter China without a visa for business, tourism, family visits, exchanges or transit, for a stay of **no more than 30 days**. The policy runs until **24:00 on 31 December 2026**; for Russia it runs until 31 December 2027. Canada and the United Kingdom were added from 17 February 2026.

- The 30 days are counted **from the day after entry** — 30 consecutive calendar days.
- You need a **valid ordinary passport**. Travel documents and temporary or emergency papers do not qualify.
- You may depart for China from any country or region, and enter through any sea, land or air port open to foreign nationals.
- **Work, study and journalism are not covered** — get a visa before you travel. So should anyone who doesn't meet the conditions.
- Carry documents that match your purpose: an invitation letter, flight and hotel bookings.

240-hour (10-day) visa-free transit

This applies to **57 countries** (40 in Europe, 6 in the Americas, 2 in Oceania, 9 in Asia). With an ordinary passport and a **confirmed onward ticket to a third country or region, with a fixed date and itinerary**, you can enter without a visa through any of **65 open ports across 24 provinces** and stay within the permitted areas for **up to 10 days**. Kyrgyzstan and Vietnam were added on 20 August 2026.

Tourism, business, visits to family and friends are fine. Work, study, journalism and other activities requiring prior approval still need a visa.

A lot of older guides still say "144-hour visa-free transit". That's out of date. It is **240 hours** now, and both the list of ports and the permitted provinces have been expanded since.

24-hour visa-free transit

All of China's open ports offer 24-hour visa-free transit to nationals of every country. With a valid international travel document and a confirmed seat on an onward connection to a third country or region, a stay of no more than 24 hours without leaving the port's restricted area requires no visa. If you want to leave that area, apply to the port's border inspection authority for a temporary entry permit.

When you're not sure, call this number

12367 is the National Immigration Administration service hotline: **24/7, with real people**, in Chinese, English, French, Russian, Japanese and Korean. Inside China dial 12367; from abroad dial **+86 12367**.

> That's the whole of the visa and entry picture — nothing held back. One thing still has to be matched to you personally: which route your passport qualifies for, and what documents to bring. Reply with your nationality and a rough itinerary and I'll confirm it.

2. Money: Paying With a Foreign Card

WeChat Pay · international cards

- **Single transaction of RMB 200 or less: no service fee.**
- **Single transaction above RMB 200: a 3% fee on the full transaction amount.**
- If the transaction is refunded, the fee is refunded in the same proportion.
- The exchange rate comes from your card network and issuing bank; your bank may also charge its own foreign transaction fee.
- The amount, rate and any waiver are shown on the payment screen — **the live screen is what counts**. Customer service: 95017.

Throughout 2026, the 3% fee continues to be waived for all international card users on single transactions of RMB 200 or less. First-time users who bind an international card and complete their first purchase get a fee waiver for 90 consecutive days on daily transactions up to RMB 1,000; that offer runs until 31 December 2026.

Alipay · international credit cards

- Paying with an international credit card carries a **flat 3% service fee**.
- Refunds made **within 30 days** of payment return the fee proportionally; after 30 days it is not returned.
- **The live payment screen is what counts.**

An easy way to remember it: with WeChat Pay, watch the RMB 200 line. With Alipay, it's a flat 3%. The two are not the same rule, so don't work out your costs as if they were.

Keep a little cash anyway

Almost everything in China can be paid for by scanning a code. But in places with no signal, when your battery dies, if binding a card fails, or for small person-to-person payments, cash is the reliable fallback. As a rule of thumb, change **¥500–1,000** at the airport and ask for ¥10 and ¥20 notes — large notes are hard to break at small shops.

> Now you have the rules. Whether you should bind a card, carry cash, or do both depends on your issuing bank, your card type, how long you're staying and whether you'll make any large purchases. Reply with those four things and I'll put together the cheapest combination for you.

3. Staying Connected

Three routes, each right for a different trip:

- **eSIM** — works the moment you land, no card swap. Best for short trips and for anyone who wants zero fuss.
- **A local SIM card** — buy at a carrier's shop with **your valid passport; real-name registration is mandatory**. Usually the cheapest option for a longer stay.
- **Your home carrier's roaming** — the easiest, no setup at all, and usually the most expensive.

Check the carriers' websites for plans before you decide whether to buy a card on arrival. If you stop using a Chinese number, you'll need to cancel it at a shop. Current prices, coverage, and whether your handset supports eSIM are best confirmed on the carrier's and your device maker's live pages.

> Your handset, the length of your stay and whether you're moving between several cities decide which of the three is cheapest for you. Tell me and I'll pick one.

4. Getting Around: Trains & Cities

- **Train tickets go on sale 15 days in advance**, counting the day of travel, nationwide.
- **Every station has its own release time.** In the Railway 12306 app, go to "My → Travel Guide → Release Time", look up your station and set a reminder. Watching that clock matters more than remembering the date.
- If a popular train sells out, use the **waitlist** — the system automatically fills cancelled seats.
- **The official 12306 website and app are the only legitimate places to buy tickets online.** Ignore third-party paid "ticket grabbing" and acceleration services; that scam catches people every year.

Within a city, use the "Metro Metropolis" app or the transit code in Alipay for the subway, and DiDi for taxis. In China the metro can take you straight from the airport to your street — it's confusing the first time, but the interchange signs will sort you out.

> Which cities you're linking together decides whether to take the train or fly, which day to book, and whether to use the waitlist. Send me your city list and your month and I'll lay it out.

5. Seasons & Crowds

Three rules of thumb:

- **Chinese New Year, the May Day holiday, National Day in October**, and the summer school holidays are nationwide peaks for crowds and prices. Popular sights, train tickets and museum reservations all tighten up. Avoid them if you can; if you can't, book early.
- China stretches a long way north to south. In the same month, Harbin and Guangzhou are in entirely different seasons. Northern winters are dry and cold; southern ones are damp and cold. Summers are hot and humid almost everywhere, and the south-east coast gets typhoons in late summer and autumn.
- Exact public holiday dates are announced each year by the State Council, so I don't print a fixed date here — it would only mislead you.

> Tell me your month and your cities and I'll put them in the right order for the weather and the crowds. Haven't chosen a date yet? Just send me the month.

6. Etiquette: Green Lights & Red Lights

Go ahead

- When your host tops up your tea or adds food to your plate, just smile and accept — it's hospitality, not a formality.
- Offer and receive business cards or gifts with both hands. A little small talk before getting down to business is expected.
- If you want to photograph a stranger, gesture first. Most people will nod and smile.

Don't

- Leave your chopsticks standing upright in a bowl of rice, or point at someone with a single finger.
- Take photos freely inside temple halls; argue loudly in public.
- Ask about someone's income, age or marriage plans on first meeting.

One phrase that gets you out of almost anything. If you can't say it, just show the characters: 请帮我一下 (qiˇng bāng woˇ yí xià) — "Please give me a hand."

> Food allergies or restrictions, children, or elderly parents in your group change the table and the itinerary completely. Tell me and I'll adjust it for you.

7. Safety & Emergencies

Situation	Call
Police / personal safety / crime	**110**
Fire & rescue	**119**
Ambulance / medical emergency	**120**
Traffic accident	**122**
Red Cross emergency (available in some cities, e.g. Beijing)	**999**
Immigration & visa questions (24/7, six languages)	**12367** · **+86 12367** from abroad

There is no single "911" in China — different emergencies have different numbers. Save these now. If you don't speak Chinese, simply show these lines to someone:

- 请帮我报警 — Please call the police for me.
- 请帮我叫救护车 — Please call an ambulance for me.
- 我的护照丢了，请帮我报警 — I've lost my passport. Please help me report it.

If you lose your passport: first report it at the nearest police station and get a **written police report**. Take that, plus a copy or photo of your passport, to your country's embassy or consulate in China for a replacement travel document. Then go to the local exit-entry administration office to sort out your visa or stay status. It often takes several working days, so leave room in your itinerary — and photograph your passport's details page before you leave home. It saves days.

For anything to do with where you're staying, **the hotel front desk is your first call**. Proper hotels have someone on duty around the clock who can translate, call the police or an ambulance, get you a taxi, or contact your consulate.

> No question left open in this chapter. If you ever need it, don't reach for the booklet — reach for the phone.

8. Packing List

- **Documents**: passport valid for your whole stay, a photo of its details page, flight and hotel bookings, insurance papers.
- **Money**: one Visa / Mastercard or similar international card that can be bound to a wallet, plus a little cash in RMB, in small notes.
- **Electronics**: a plug adapter (China uses 220V), a power bank, an offline translation app, and your eSIM or local-SIM plan.
- **Clothes**: layers that work for the season and for the north–south gap; one genuinely comfortable pair of walking shoes — Chinese sights involve far more walking than most people expect.
- **Medicine**: keep everyday medication in its original packaging with the English label; bring enough for any long-term condition, plus the prescription.
- Before you fly, save the Chinese phrases from Chapter 7 into your notes app or an offline translator.

This Kit gives you the rules that apply to everyone. Your trip needs its own version.

Reply to Lao Ai with four lines: your country / your month / your days / who's coming with you. I'll send back a plan for your trip, not another generic list.

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